

Episode 157: Long Ago... 95 1995 Part 15 Production Going Smoothly?

September and October

The TV series *Hakaba Kitaro* Blu-ray Box that I participated in will be released February 23rd. Last winter we created jacket artwork for this Box with Director Chioka's design concept, Animation Director Yamamuro's animation, and my colour work, which the jacket designer worked hard to compile. This turned out quite well! Once you get your hands on it, you'll definitely want it! Such a jacket. So everyone, even those who already have the DVD-BOX, please consider it! ...Promotion, promotion (laugh).

During that *Hakaba Kitaro* jacket work, I heard that Blu-ray conversion of old works, especially TV series, is quite difficult. Recent TV works produced with HD standards and Blu-ray release in mind from the start are one thing, but to convert footage produced in old TV standards to Blu-ray requires remastering processing to convert the footage itself to Blu-ray standards - that effort is quite demanding and costs considerably. This becomes a bottleneck preventing old works from becoming Blu-ray. Since costs must be added to the price, sales prices inevitably become somewhat high, and even when made and released that way, they don't sell much - massive losses. So unless you know a work was popular enough to guarantee certain sales numbers, you can't easily release Blu-ray Boxes.

My amateur thinking is, for example, keeping image quality exactly as when released on DVD - then lots would fit on one Blu-ray, so you could put entire series on 2-3 discs! But apparently that's not such a simple matter either (bitter laugh). Hmm, difficult.

Old works aside, I record quite a bit of recent terrestrial digital TV anime on home Blu-ray, but honestly, once you record and save to Blu-ray yourself, you don't need to buy released commercial Blu-ray Boxes.

Hmm, difficult...

Even so, even so, please purchase *Hakaba Kitaro* Blu-ray Box!

Anyway.

Season progresses from autumn to late autumn. *Neighbourhood Story* production proceeded almost smoothly. Around early autumn 1995. Weekly broadcasting means completing one episode weekly - weekly editing and dubbing, and art meetings at roughly the same weekly pace.

When director's storyboard is completed and gets OK from producer and series director, and animation meetings are almost finished, art meetings immediately follow. Art meetings (美打ち) are attended by that episode's director, assistant director, art director, that episode's art staff, colour design (me), and colour direction staff. Toei's production system has no setting production. Setting-related management and handling is done by assistant directors. Also, I don't know from when, but in Toei Animation's system, production staff (production progress) rarely attend TV series art meetings. I think it's questionable that production doesn't attend, but since assistant directors are present, it's considered acceptable. Quite a system not found at other studios.

So, such art meetings.

Often art meetings are scheduled when a certain number of background layouts are ready, but in *Neighbourhood Story*, since art meetings also served as art board meetings, meetings were scheduled at early points. As I wrote before, *Neighbourhood Story* has a large production volume done at the Manila, Philippines studio, so early episode startup was required for that reason too. Particularly since photography would also be done at Manila studio, retake response needed proper time allocation, requiring stricter schedule management than other domestic photography series (...but reality was that it didn't go so smoothly (bitter laugh)).

Background work procedure: each episode's art staff first organises and corrects background layouts from animation according to actual art settings. Background work

begins with corrected layouts, most of which were sent to Manila studio for Filipino staff to draw. Depending on content, some scenes and cuts were better handled by designers or domestic staff, so those were domestic work, but almost everything else was Manila work. Actually, since Manila studio also handled photography portions, that was sometimes more convenient.

Meanwhile, us colour direction folks. I didn't handle main story colour direction work - we asked someone else. Kinugasa-san, a senior company colour direction staff member. A division system where I did colour design (色彩設計) and Kinugasa-san did colour direction (色指定). This pattern would continue for all episodes. Colour design me would create character colours and get approval, making colouring settings (色指定書) up to that point. Colour direction Kinugasa-san would put colour direction into each episode's main story animation based on these materials and art meeting content. For cuts that differed from art meeting content or changed, we'd consult and decide processing and direction each time. This style would continue in this slot for years to come.

Until now, for any work I handled, I'd do colour design myself and then do all colour direction myself too, but "dividing this work" didn't suit me in various ways. But since this was also a new approach, I thought methods would gradually suit me through working in this system, and even if some things didn't work well, there must be good solutions. That's how I began. Everything is experience.

Neighbourhood Story would go with "no shadows" visually - this was a "rule" from the beginning, but directional points weren't limited to that, and scenes or cuts wanting impression could have shadows added in animation. However, the method was somewhat unusual - shadow parts were created as separate cels painted BL (black) (positive mask), then half-exposure photographed during shooting.

Why use such methods? First, you get more matte feel than shadows normally painted with cel paint. Shadow brightness and saturation balance for skin shadows, paper shadows, clothing shadows becomes uniform. And shadow strength (brightness) can be

adjusted and controlled according to scene and cut meaning. For example, if normal double-brush density is 50%, scenes wanting more shocking impression could use 60% or 70% stronger density for darker shadows, expressing that character's mental state and shock feeling.

Also, *Neighbourhood Story* didn't set so-called "night colour" special colouring tones. This was also processed during photography. Scenes wanting night colouring like outdoor night scenes were shot with blue filters applied to the entire screen.

Night scene backgrounds were drawn with somewhat reduced colouring and brightness, but *Neighbourhood Story's* art style was graphical like original visuals - utilising black-painted parts and firmly drawing outline lines, so light blue filters didn't change background impressions much, rather preserving good moist colouring. And cel paintings finished in overall bright tones with basically no shadows appeared slightly darker with blue tint added, matching night backgrounds at just the right balance. Evening scenes were probably roughly the same.

However, as the series entered the latter half, irregular methods were gradually incorporated responding to story excitement. Sometimes shadows were normally painted with cel paint, or night colour and evening tones were set and painted as special colouring. "Rules" existed as "rules," but new attempts and conversely orthodox methods would also be used. Since presentation "rules" had taken hold among viewers in the latter half, various things could be tried as expressive range.

Digital processing-like screen creation using computers was also incorporated into main episodes. But using digital composite processing like the opening in TV series main episodes lacked budget and especially time. Still, for cuts wanting particularly impressive presentation at scene endings and episode endings, we shot using materials processed by computer like "harmony processing." Methods like overlapping computer-processed printouts onto normal cel + background combinations. Incidentally, such processing was usually done by me or art staff Gyo-san, but in the latter half, directors and assistant directors increasingly did such work too.

But these were all still early series stages. Still just starting to run. First was the stage of establishing these "rules."

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